Land
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Part One
A Peninsula, Stretching Out Into the Atlantic

Liam's father, Tomas, was a man of few words. The two of them were self-employed, walking around the peninsula with their surveying poles. Liam was ten years old, and his jacket was covered in patches from his mother's mending; he was as proud of them as if they were postage stamps. His father, a small dot in the distance, was motioning something to him. Liam was cold and struggled to keep the surveying pole upright. His father kept motioning, then came over to him. Tomas was useful to the soldiers: there were plenty of men who could survey, but only he could talk with the locals and also make the calculations. Once he had finished surveying, the redcoats would come in, collate the work, and put their own grand names on the map.
Tomas asked Liam what he had been saying, and Liam asked whether they were finished. His father did not like him to be weak. Tomas could see that the wind had chilled the boy, but he needed to finish the map that week because the soldiers were coming, and he could not afford sentiment. He told Liam to hold the pole and went back to note down a boulder.
Liam was thinking about his sister, Enda. He heard her calling after him, but when he turned around, no one was there. He wandered into the copse and felt as though he were being entwined by the hands of the dead children buried there during the Great Hunger. Liam screamed, and his father came down and told him not to be frightened. Liam saw a woman driving a heifer, with a dog at her side. When he came back to his senses, he could not find his father. Thinking that Tomas had gone down the hill without him, Liam went back to the widow who gave them lodging whenever they came to make the map. She told him his father had not returned, and the boy sat down beside her. She looked after him, gave him a jersey to wear, and sent some men out to look for Tomas. They searched the peninsula but could not find him. The boy fell asleep after a meal of milk and bread.
The widow had met Liam and his father only a day earlier, when Tomas showed her a map of the town made twenty years before, before the Great Hunger. Looking at it, she was like a bird gazing down on the town of the past. She told them about the houses that had been left empty; she knew every place. She did not say everything aloud and kept some of it to herself, but Tomas understood her and patted her hand.
Liam was woken by laughter outside the widow's house. The widow was still asleep. Then the door burst open, and a man who looked like his father, covered in ferns and leaves, was led in by two other men. Tomas had been looking for his son because he wanted to tell him about a discovery. He was unusually talkative, and the widow

thought he was drunk. Tomas gave Liam a pebble and said he had found the spring, the tobar. He told Liam that surveying poles and theodolites were necessary but were only playthings; what really mattered were the layers of the map and the ancestry beneath them.

Years later, in his thirty-first year, Liam would find himself under interrogation in Calcutta, holding a parakeet's feather. There he asked the men about the spring, the tobar, and they were confused.

Back in the widow's house, Liam did not understand what was happening, but his father kept pouring out words for three days without touching the maps. Tomas had not slept for days, and he asked Liam to build a fire to burn the maps, telling him that maps were weapons of colonisation. Liam took the maps and hid them, and the widow calmed Tomas down. Tomas then drew a map of his own, saying that facts are myths and myths are facts. He told Liam to travel the world, learn foreign languages, and come back to the well if he did not like the weather. He also told Liam to keep the feather, look after the birds, and give the feather back only to its owner. On the fifth day, the priest came.

Tomas remembered nothing of his early life except being brought to a workhouse by two men. He could already speak four languages, and he was chosen to recite the catechism and the multiplication tables whenever visitors came to the workhouse. It was there that he met a girl named Seraphina, known as Phina.

The priest had heard about the spring and its magical water, and he could not tolerate pagan worship, so he came down to see Tomas. Tomas answered the priest's questions cleverly. The priest looked at Tomas's drawings: they were maps, but in the wrong languages. Tomas kept saying that he had been making the wrong maps in the wrong language. The priest believed he knew what had possessed Tomas, since he had warned against it in his sermons and in his book. He took out his book and began reading prayers.

Liam came down to the widow's house and found his father tied up. The priest told him to finish the maps for the sake of his two sisters. Liam nodded and began drawing.

Tomas's life in the workhouse had been hard. He worked in the basement with the other children, mending shoes and learning other trades. The warden's wife took Phina's shawl from her. Tomas and Phina talked about getting out of the workhouse. They watched children go out as hired hands for farmers, and at first Tomas wanted to be one of them, but when the children came back fewer in number and with tired eyes, he changed his mind. Two years passed in the workhouse.

Liam could not draw maps the way his father did, but he had heard his parents discussing landlords, so he tried his best to draw them as Tomas would. Meanwhile, Tomas was tied to a table while a figure murmured beside him, telling him to repent and confess. Tomas was himself again. He remembered going down to retrieve Liam's shoe and discovering the stream. He had drunk from it and been struck by a dilemma: if he put the stream on the map, the viscount would fell the trees and redirect the water, yet

his vocation demanded precision and accuracy. He drank again, trying to quench the fire inside him. The question of whether the stream belonged on the map or only on the land was driving him mad.

Then he was brought back to the room and the dark-robed figure. The priest was eating, while Tomas had been given nothing for two days. He fought against the hunger, telling himself that he had survived the workhouse and his apprenticeship and would survive this too. But when more food was brought to the priest, a sentence slipped out of his mouth, begging for a morsel. The priest told him he must repent, and Tomas broke. The priest believed that his fight against the devil was nearly won, and he planned to write to the bishop about it. Liam had finished the maps by the time he saw the priest come out with his father. Tomas wept as he ate the bread.

Long before, Tomas had been picking oakum in the workhouse when a redcoat came looking for a chain boy, because the previous one had been found washed up in the stream. The redcoat chose a different boy, but Tomas stepped forward and chalked a map on the board, and the job was his. He was given a place to sleep with the soldiers in the barracks.

When the redcoats came to collect the maps, Liam brought his father out to them. They gave Tomas a purse of coins. His father said nothing.

Liam held his father's hand and led him back to Dublin, hoping the familiar streets and sounds would help him heal. At home, Liam heard Enda singing, Rose ran to hug her father, and they learned that their mother was expecting a new baby. Liam's mother used the larger part of the money to pay the rent man and the grocer, and hid the smaller portion away for lean times. His father curled up under all the blankets and wept at night in sudden outbursts. Their mother said it was the illness, and the neighbours asked the children about it. Liam stayed home from school for two days. On the third day, his mother made him go, but when he came back and saw her tending his father, he returned to school.

After two years of surveying with the redcoats, Tomas was promoted to civilian assistant with a salary. He went back to the workhouse and learned that Phina's father had come looking for her, but the warden had told him there was no girl named Phina there, only a Frances. Phina was heartbroken when she learned that her father had left without her, and the warden was now sending her to the penal colony in Australia to be a servant or a wife. Tomas found out which port the ship was leaving from and went after her. He found the ship, and a sailor helped him locate the girls from the workhouse. Tomas took Phina off the ship, punching an old man from the workhouse who tried to stop them.

Back in the present, Phina was combing Rose's hair. She did not know how to care for Tomas in his illness and had no one to ask. Her own parents had given her no example of marriage to draw on. She wanted Tomas to go back to work, and she did not want to dig into her savings. Then Tomas stood up and told her he had made a decision, but he did not say what it was, and went out. Liam, Enda, and Rose were arguing when he

came back and announced that he had a lease from the viscount's land secretary: they would be living on the peninsula where he and Liam had surveyed.

Part Two

The Exact Place Where, Millennia Later, Liam Will Stand Waiting for His Father to Reappear

A girl named Birth was searching for her father with her mother, who carried a child on her back, and a hound. Her father had left them a season before. Birth gave her mother a cup of water from the stream, knowing that it was special and could heal her mother's grief. The teller had told Birth that her father came from a tribe of wanderers, and that his kind always moved from place to place. Birth picked up a ring from the stream, and a fish came and asked for it back, but Birth swallowed the ring. Her father never returned, and her mother rejected other suitors. When the place was struck by a bloating sickness, the elders decided that Birth should be sacrificed. The teller tried to stop them, but they would not listen. They put Birth and the hound in a pit, and there, against all odds, the two of them remained together for centuries.

Much later, a woman climbed the hill, followed by her man. Their village had been destroyed by men who looked like giants and who had killed some of their holy men. The woman was looking for the spring to help her conceive a child. They spoke a different language from the one Birth had spoken centuries before. The man with the ash stick waited with his dog, which sensed the bones and other things buried beneath. The woman came out with her face and tunic wet, looking happy. They settled on the flat part of the high ground, and the woman became pregnant. Years followed years, and their descendants lived in the hut, until they moved down to the shore near the monastery, where the widow lived. The giants came again and killed the holy men, and the people went to the spring to pray for peace. The land witnessed conquests by kings from neighbouring lands. Families dug the ground where Birth and her hound lay, and she felt the thud of every spade, the ring still in her stomach. Then the Great Hunger came for the family living in the house. They survived the first winter, but the second took half of them, and the viscount gave them no help. In the end, the Great Hunger took them all.

Then a man with a surveying pole and a child came into the copse, and later the man returned with his family. Tomas smiled at Phina, but she could not bear the house. It was in ruins and needed repairs that would take weeks, so she told Tomas she could not live there and left. The widow on the shore took Phina in and let her stay until the house was repaired; she was fond of Liam. Tomas and Phina talked, and she asked him to repair the house and take the wages from the redcoats. Tomas refused to survey for the redcoats again, but he gave in when Phina told him she would not let her children

starve. Phina and the children stayed at the widow's while Tomas repaired the house. Beneath the ground, Birth felt the new house above her.

Phina and the children moved in. Enda wandered around until nightfall, while Rose stayed by her mother's side. Phina found a feather in Rose's hand, which Rose had found under the bed. It reminded Phina of her childhood, of the shawl her father had brought her, and of how she had lost him. The feather came from that shawl, from the piece Tomas had cut off when she arrived at the workhouse.

Enda did not like the menial work on the farm, such as milking the cows every day. When the priest came to take Liam to his school, Enda wanted to go too, but the priest said she was too old, even though she was good at arithmetic and recitation. She went down to the river. Phina came after her and told her to go to the widow's house, and when Enda went for the bread, the widow gave her a box with a fiddle inside. Enda loved the magical sound of its four strings and practised for hours, until Phina asked her to stop for a while. So Enda took Rose out into the woods. Rose did not want to go into the copse, because their father had told them not to, but Enda went ahead and Rose followed. Suddenly they were confronted by what looked like a hellhound. Rose hid behind Enda, and then Enda burst out laughing: the dog was friendly. Meanwhile, Liam was sitting in the schoolhouse.

Rose and Enda chose their words carefully to persuade their father to let them keep the dog. When they entered the house, they noticed a difference in the air: their mother had given birth to a boy named Eugene. The widow said that the first birth on the island in a long time would bring better times. Fishermen and others came to see him and brought Phina gifts for the baby. Liam was studying Latin and did not want to disappoint the priest. He forgot how to write a sentence in Latin, then remembered Enda's advice to start with the verb. The priest thought the boy had a gift that he could mould. He did not understand why the bishop had not replied to his letter, and he decided that he must take the road of humility.

Tomas received a commission from the redcoats to go to an island and map it over the winter, and he decided to take Liam with him. When Tomas saw the dog, Bran, he allowed Enda and Rose to keep it to guard them. Tomas felt the dog's gaze on him and told Phina that it knew something about him. Liam did not want to go to the island because he had to sit an exam, but Tomas promised to study with him every day, and Liam agreed. Liam found a medallion and went to the copse to find the well. He had imagined it would be filled with offerings, but there were none. So he prayed that he would not become a mapmaker but a priest. The medallion slipped into the well, and he heard a noise behind him. It was Enda, who had been eavesdropping. She played the fiddle and mocked his prayer. Liam chased her up a tree but fell with a thud. Woken by the noise, Phina sent Enda to fetch the two sisters who set bones. She did not want Tomas to postpone his trip and lose the pay, so she told Enda to go with Tomas in Liam's place.

On the ship to the island, Tomas noticed how enthusiastic "Liam" seemed. When he looked closer, he saw that it was Enda. She told him about Liam's broken bones and said that Phina had sent her in his place. The labourers on the ship teased Enda, but she fought back. When they reached the island, she was put in the care of an old couple. Tomas wrote the progress report on the sixteen-week expedition, which the two sappers signed. One night, Tomas heard Enda playing the fiddle beautifully; the old couple had taught her while he was out making maps.
Bran sensed something different about the newborn Eugene, as if the baby knew things about all of them. By the time Tomas and Enda returned four months later, Eugene was a year old. He had been a quiet baby. Eugene did not speak, but like Bran, he took everything in. He communicated with signs, and Rose became his guardian and protector. He watched Tomas and Liam drift apart, Enda read Liam's books, and Rose look after him. One day Eugene dug into the soil and found a ring and a girl holding a dog that looked like Bran. He took the ring but gently covered the girl, whose eyelids were closed, with soil again. Then he found his mother, who told him she had a terrible feeling and lay down with her face on the sand. His mother died, and Liam and Tomas argued over her burial. Tomas wanted to bury her on their land, but in the end she was buried in the village.

Part Three
Sail the Wide Sea

The interrogation in Calcutta had been going on for three days. Liam listened to the committee members' questions. They wanted to know who had ordered him to do this, and they suggested it was his father, Tomas. Liam did not want to talk about his father, so he told them it was the priest, Father Joseph. They did not believe him and asked what had made him leave the priesthood.
After Phina's death, Liam and Tomas stopped speaking to each other. Rose took on all the chores and, against the odds, made sure everyone was fed and the house was kept in order. Enda spent most of her time playing for strangers for very little money. She told Rose that the money did not matter, because she was learning tunes from all over the world. Eugene sensed that something was going on with Liam: he was leaving home to join the novitiate. Tomas was terribly silent, and Liam was the only thing that still interested him. Then Enda overheard Tomas asking Liam not to go to the novitiate. He urged Liam to sail the wide ocean instead and gave him a letter granting "permission to emigrate," along with money in his name that Phina and Tomas had been saving so that he could emigrate. Tomas told him he did not have to decide when to go, but that he should keep the money.

On the day Liam left his family, he felt Eugene's intent gaze on him. Rose and Enda said goodbye, but Tomas did not say a word to him. When Liam arrived at the House of First Formation, he felt that he was the only one from the country, as the others came from wealthy families.

Because the rent had gone up, Rose asked Tomas to take a month's work drawing maps for the redcoats. Tomas said he was too old for it, but Rose and Enda got him ready for the job anyway. One day, while Tomas was making calculations on the root of a tree, the cart's wheel got stuck in the mud. The tall sapper yelled at him, yanked him by the collar, and told him to push the cart. The chain boy said that Tomas was too old, but the soldiers told him to shut up. Tomas tried to push the wheel out of the mud, but the tall sapper grabbed the bridle, the donkey jerked the cart forward, and Tomas's hand was caught between the wheel and the road. He was taken to the nearest hospital, where the hand that had drawn such beautiful coastlines was found to be crushed to pulp. Tomas was given laudanum and dreamed of his family. The doctor amputated his arm at the wrist, and then at the elbow, to prevent infection.

Liam was dusting the tops of the bookshelves in a library. Since his fall during the fight with Enda, he had been afraid of heights, but as a postulant he could not refuse the task. As he slowly climbed down the ladder, another "Liam" was waiting in a queue for a ship bound for Quebec. The officers barely glanced at the tickets. It was Enda, boarding a ship to emigrate. Back home, Rose was waiting for her father so she could tell him how cruel Enda had been to leave without a word. Then two soldiers brought her father back and handed her his medicine. The widow and the bone-setting sisters came to pray for him. Rose nursed him and gave him the medicine until it ran out. Her father woke with a scream and compared the lengths of his arms. Rose told him that Enda had gone to Canada.

Liam and the other novices fasted for a day and confessed their sins to a priest. At home, Rose suggested that Tomas write to the redcoats asking for compensation, an idea she had learned from Father Joseph. Tomas told her to let Father Joseph write it for her. On the ship, Enda was asked to play a tune on her fiddle on deck. One week passed, then another, then another, and she lost count of the days. During a storm, they were forced to stay below deck for three days. A baby, three children, five women, and two men died during the voyage. At last, they sighted land.

On market day, Rose was selling eggs near the clock tower, thinking about Enda and Eugene. She sold some to a lady, and then the viscount's family came by. She quoted them a steep price, expecting them to refuse, but the viscount's wife paid it. Tomas was watching Rose from a corner. Since the redcoats had replied to his letter, he had been receiving a monthly stipend for the accident, and he spent most of his time walking around. He thought about his family, about never being able to finish his own version of the maps, and about his first-born son being gone. He believed that disguising Enda as Liam had planted the seed of all their troubles: Enda would not have left if she had not

learned to play on the island. Enda had always been more interested in his work than Liam was. Rose had little happiness, and her brother was her only comfort. Tomas thought about going to stand beside her while she sold the eggs. Then he saw the viscount's son eyeing Rose, and he frowned. Rose gave the young man no encouragement. Tomas walked on.

Part Four

Off to the Edge of the Charted World

Enda got off the ship at Quebec and saw many ships unloading passengers in the bay. She wondered whether there could be jobs for so many people. In the immigration queue, she stood near a couple. The man spoke three languages, and he noticed that she was a woman. Enda showed her documents to the officer, who stamped them, recording that a man named Liam had entered the country. The couple warned her that she would have to go through a medical check, which would reveal that her documents did not match her body. But the doctors had no time to notice: they found a rash on her abdomen, and she was taken to the quarantine hospital.

The viscount was looking out of his window. He knew what was happening in the country, but he did not want to give in. His son's bills lay on the table, and he would not pay them for him again. A skylark flew from the viscount's window to Eugene, who was climbing a hill. Eugene saw the viscount's steward tearing down a notice from a signpost. The notice urged the people who laboured for the viscount to resist. Eugene also noticed that the viscount's gardens had been left untended.

After six weeks in quarantine, Enda took a ferry to Quebec. She looked for the couple, hoping she could stay with them for the night. She found a place to stay, but a drunk man attacked her there. She fought back and knocked him down. She left in the morning and went from one boarding house to another. At the fourth, she found a clean room to share with a girl from Belgium. But then her money went missing, and she was thrown out. She slept under a bench near a fountain in a park.

In Rome, Liam was studying at a college under his spiritual master. He had to do menial tasks without speaking to anyone, and he counted the days until he could go out into the city. Meanwhile, Enda slept under the bench and went out each day to look for work, but she could not find any because she had no one to give her a reference. One night, she could not bring herself to sleep under the bench again, so she went into a church and slept there. She fell into a deep, peaceful sleep and was woken by a priest, who told her about a job as a hired girl. Enda met the cook of a trader's family, who helped her get a week's trial, and she got the job. She worked there for some months. When the family left Quebec for their other house for the winter, Enda stayed behind and worked at a hotel. When they came back, Enda told them she was leaving Quebec

for Trois-Rivières, and the cook told her to come and find her when she returned. Enda paid for her passage on the ferry by cleaning the windows and tables, and she posted a letter to Rose. When Enda played her fiddle for the crowds, one of the men invited her to play for some coins, and soon the coins were raining down on her. She was invited to play at parties and weddings, and she decided it was better to wear boys' clothes. Her landlady shrugged; she did not care, as long as Enda did not bring men back.

Liam was taking an examination; if he passed, he would be sent to India and given the name Father Gulielmus. He heard the other boys preparing for the procession. Two years had passed since Enda left home, and she kept asking her landlady whether a letter had come from Rose. Feeling homesick, she played mournful tunes at an inn until she could not bear it and switched to another tune. A man was watching her intently, and Enda went stiff. He put a coin in her case but kept staring. Then he mentioned a place, and Enda realized that he was the man from the couple who had helped her at immigration. His name was Anatole, and the woman had been his sister. He worked at the inn, and his sister lived in Quebec. Anatole played the accordion, so he asked Enda to play with him some time. He invited her to dinner, and they ate together. Then an old piper began playing a tune about a red-haired girl. He was Phina's father, the man who had gone back to the workhouse looking for her, but Enda did not know that he was her grandfather. When Enda returned to the boarding house, the landlady gave her a letter. Enda tried to smell the air of the peninsula on it, but she was too nervous. It contained only a single paragraph from Father Joseph, informing her that her father, Tomas, had passed away.

Rose and Eugene were mowing the land. Eugene was fifteen years old and the tallest of them all. Rose kept up a conversation by herself, asking and answering her own questions. The widow told them to come and sleep at her house to ease their loneliness. Father Joseph told Rose that her father had been found lying under a tree, wrapped in a blanket, watching the world and at peace. Rose did not believe that her father had been at peace; he had always been restless. Eugene mowed so fast that she could not keep up. Rose thought about her family and realized that she knew nothing of her father's and mother's roots.

In South India, Liam was thinking about his family. He wanted to wear a hat like the locals to keep off the sun, but he was told he must stay apart from them. Then a man came to him and asked Liam to use his magic on his son, who had been born early. Liam told him he had no magic, but he remembered Eugene and decided to pray for the child.

Enda met Anatole after his shifts at the inn. They played together outside and were sometimes invited to play inside people's apartments, and Anatole split the coins with her equally. Then he began to make advances, and they kissed in an alley.

Eugene remembered the day Rose told him she had to step out while the bread was rising. Outside, she saw the viscount's son and another man beating a pup. She tried to stop them, but they turned on her. Bran held them off for a while, but when they caught

Rose, the viscount's son tried to unbutton her dress. Then Eugene struck both men with a spade. The widow saw Eugene coming into her house, and then she found the bodies of the viscount's son, the other gentleman, Rose, and Bran. She thought Eugene was the only survivor until she saw Rose's ribcage rising. They pushed the two men's bodies off the cliff and buried Bran. Eugene saw storms coming. The widow told them to leave and gave them her money.

In Cochin, Liam saw people talking outside his house. He was teaching his students when a letter arrived. It had taken a year to reach him, and from it he learned that his father had been injured and had died. There was no news of Rose or Eugene. His devotion to the priesthood was wavering, and he could not explain why. He listened to his students learning Pythagoras's theorem and saw the Provincial praying beside him. Liam was overseeing the building of a church and a college for priests, and he could not bear to watch the people suffer as they built it. He began to question his faith and realized he had been blind not to see that the priest had led him away from his father. He wanted to talk to his sister Enda. All of this was what he told his superiors when they questioned him in Calcutta. Then a man entered: the Provincial Superior, their last attempt to keep Liam. Liam told him he had lost his faith, and the Provincial took the crucifix from around his neck and told him to leave.

A man and a woman who looked like a couple were on a ship. They were Rose and Eugene, who had bought passage to Quebec. When the ship reached the open Atlantic, they caught their last sight of their homeland. Eugene put a small puppy into Rose's hands and jumped into the water.

Liam was also in the city, wearing clothes given to him by a merchant. He tried to sleep, but the noise in the apartment kept him awake. He tried to reason with a crowd, but they would not listen. Liam realized that he was no longer a priest. He decided to stay in the city and find work before going home, because he did not want to return to his family a failure.

Enda was scrubbing the floor and feeding the fire. Anatole had gone out of town for the summer and left his accordion with her. She waited for him for weeks, but he did not come back, so she went to his employer's office to ask about him. The clerk told her that Anatole had been killed in an accident, and that they would take care of his wife and family. Enda left the office and wandered the streets. When she got back to her room, she looked feverish, and the landlady left her alone. On the third day, a knock woke her. It was Rose, who scolded her for leaving her behind.

Liam thought about teaching, but he could not face the questions about where he had studied. So he went to the surveying office and gave the clerk his father's name. The officer gave Liam some calculations to try, and he solved them in a flash. Liam wrote to the peninsula that he had found a job, and that they would laugh if they knew what it was. He drew maps of the country. He wrote again but received no reply. Liam married a girl from the inn. His letters to the peninsula came back marked "GONE AWAY," so he

wrote to Father Joseph and the widow, but those letters came back marked "BOTH DECEASED." So he went back to the peninsula to see the cabin. The peninsula had a new viscount, a distant relative of the old one. The local children told him that a goblin-like creature lived in the cabin up the hill. He climbed the hill and found the land well tended. Then he went into the copse, heard footsteps, and ran.
Eugene did not know that the man was his brother, Liam, and he hid in the copse. Eugene had been saved by the tide, which carried him ashore. He walked on, surviving on berries, until he reached the peninsula. The widow came to him and gave him a hen to breed. Eugene mended the house and tended the land. He could not find the man who had come. Eugene sat down by the well and drank the water. Then a fish came and asked for the ring. Eugene took the ring from his finger and threw it into the spring, and the fish swam deeper until it disappeared.
Eugene lived for more than a hundred years. He had everything he needed. He knew that Enda and Rose were together, with a boy, that Rose had a good husband, and that Liam lived not far away. The children who lived at the widow's old house grew up, and the village talked about the "Gruagach" who lived up the hill. The viscount's estate was broken up. The people of the peninsula spoke of a wise man who knew the land.

Summary written by Thura Htoo.

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